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Central and Peripheral Routes Shaping Trust and Purchase on Short Video Platforms in the AI-Generated Content Era

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Abstract: This study examines how central processing factors (information authenticity, information literacy) and peripheral motivations (entertainment, socialization, status seeking, passing time) influence user trust and purchase intention on short video platforms, considering the context of rapidly expanding AI-generated content. Drawing on the Elaboration Likelihood Model and Uses and Gratifications Theory, a dual-pathway model was tested using survey data from 652 Chinese users and analyzed via PLS-SEM and multi-group analysis. Results show both central and peripheral routes significantly impact trust and sharing intention, which mediate continuance and purchase intentions. Central-route factors primarily drive trust, while peripheral motivations stimulate sharing. Gender differences emerged: women are more influenced by social and entertainment motives, men by status and utilitarian needs. Findings highlight the need for platforms to enhance content authenticity and user literacy, and to tailor motivational strategies for different user groups. This research extends theoretical understanding of user engagement and provides actionable implications for platform design and digital marketing in the AI-generated content era

Keywords: AI-generated content; Short video platforms; Elaboration Likelihood Model; Uses and Gratifications Theory; Purchase intention.

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1 Introduction

Short video platforms are increasingly embedded in people's everyday lives, serving as vital channels for digital social interaction and entertainment. They shape media preferences, modes of engagement, and consumer decision-making processes (Tian et al., 2023). Evolving from spaces of content exchange into integrated digital ecosystems, these platforms now converge entertainment, user-generated content, and e-commerce (Gao et al., 2021). In China, platforms like TikTok and Kuaishou have drawn hundreds of millions of users through algorithm-driven recommendation systems and participatory content creation mechanisms (Cheng et al., 2023). Users on these platforms simultaneously act as content recipients, producers, and distributors, while also functioning as potential consumers of platform-based goods and services. As a result, content and commerce have become increasingly interwoven, forming a dynamic consumption ecosystem (Huang et al., 2025).

However, the rapid growth of short video platforms has also raised important psychological and cognitive concerns, particularly surrounding content reliability and the proliferation of misinformation (Kwok and Koh, 2021). With the rising accessibility of generative AI (AIGC) technologies, producing videos for science communication, entertainment, or product evaluation has become significantly easier. While this surge in rapidly generated content broadens the information landscape, it also amplifies users' concerns about authenticity and quality. Trust—widely recognized as a central factor in user decision-making (Zhai and Chen, 2023)—is shaped by content perception and individual evaluative capacities, and it significantly influences both content sharing and continued use (Fan et al., 2021; Shi et al., 2023).

Scholars in psychology and communication have examined user behavior on short video platforms from various angles, including trust, motivation, satisfaction, and platform engagement. For example, trust in new media content affects users' willingness to engage (Fan et al., 2021), and user engagement has been linked to stronger purchase intentions (Sun et al., 2020). Satisfaction, in turn, is shaped by factors such as content quality, social interaction features, and recommendation systems (Qi et al., 2024). Other studies have noted links between video-sharing behavior and continued use among millennials (He et al., 2024), as well as the role of privacy and data protection in influencing long-term platform engagement (Mou et al., 2021). Furthermore, researchers have explored how intrinsic motivation and external social cues influence information sharing on short video platforms (Omar et al., 2024).

Despite these efforts, existing research lacks an integrated framework that connects cognitive processing and psychological needs to explain how users move from content evaluation to trust, motivation, and behavior. This limitation is especially salient in the AIGC era, where empirical insights remain scarce regarding why users choose to share self-generated or AIGC, and how these actions evolve into platform loyalty and purchasing behavior (Shi et al., 2023). To fill this gap, a more holistic framework is needed to explain how cognitive judgments and motivational responses jointly shape user behavior in algorithmically mediated environments.

Grounded in the Elaboration Likelihood Model and the Uses and Gratifications Theory, this study proposes a dual-pathway model capturing the user journey from information processing to behavioral response. The ELM posits that individuals process information via two distinct routes: a central route characterized by deliberate, analytical engagement with message content, and a peripheral route that involves more heuristic processing driven by emotion, identity, or other contextual cues (Petty et al., 1983; Petty et al., 1986). This model has proven useful across advertising, branding, and digital media research for explaining shifts in attitudes and behavior (Luo et al., 2024).

Applying this framework to short video platforms, the present study explores how both central and peripheral cues influence users' trust and content sharing. On the central route, two cognitive factors are examined: users' perceived authenticity of AIGC-generated content and their level of information literacy. Prior studies show that information literacy improves individuals' ability to evaluate the credibility and accuracy of content (Hobbs, 2013), while perceived authenticity strengthens trust and increases willingness to share (Zhang and Patrick, 2021). Though most of this work has occurred outside short video contexts, it offers valuable insights for understanding trust formation in digitally saturated environments. To date, however, empirical research specifically examining the authenticity–trust–sharing chain in AIGC contexts remains limited

(Sun and Xie, 2024).

On the peripheral route, psychological needs—such as entertainment, recognition, and social connection—have been shown to influence content sharing without requiring intensive cognitive effort (Thompson et al., 2020). This study thus distinguishes the effects of central and peripheral routes on trust and sharing intentions and empirically tests both paths. It also examines whether sharing intention drives continued use and whether continued use translates into actual purchases within the platform, thereby constructing a full behavioral chain from cognition to consumption. Finally, building on research showing that gender may influence cognitive processing, motivational drivers, and behavioral tendencies (Zhou et al., 2014), the study introduces gender as a moderating variable through multigroup analysis to assess potential heterogeneity in the pathway structure.

To address these questions, the study investigates:

(1) How does sharing intention influence continued use, and does continued use lead to purchase behavior?

(2) Do central and peripheral route factors affect users' sharing intention?

(3) Does trust mediate the relationship between central route variables and sharing behavior?

(4) Do these relationships differ significantly by gender?

This study offers four key contributions. Theoretically, it advances a dual-path model combining cognition and motivation to explain short video behavior. Mechanistically, it integrates sharing, sustained use, and purchasing into a coherent pathway. Analytically, it reveals gender-based heterogeneity in behavioral mechanisms. Practically, it provides guidance for enhancing content credibility, refining algorithmic design, and improving commercial outcomes under AIGC conditions.

2 Theoretical and literature foundation

2.1 Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM)

The Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) seeks to explain how individuals form and change their attitudes when exposed to persuasive information (Petty *et al.,* 1986). As a classic dual-process theory of information processing, ELM posits that people evaluate persuasive messages through two distinct cognitive routes: the central route and the peripheral route. The central route involves rational analysis and critical evaluation of message content. When individuals possess sufficient motivation and cognitive resources, they tend to process information more deeply—examining its logical structure, factual basis, and underlying implications—leading to more enduring attitude changes (Moradi and Zihagh, 2022). In contrast, the peripheral route applies when cognitive engagement is limited. In such cases, individuals rely on external cues, such as emotional appeal or source familiarity, to form quick judgments. These processes require less cognitive effort and are more susceptible to contextual or affective influences (Shi *et al.,* 2018).

With the rise of social media, ELM has been widely applied to examine how users process content, form attitudes, and engage in behaviors. It has been used to investigate users' cognitive mechanisms in content reception (Liao and Huang, 2021), the correction of misinformation through central and peripheral routes (Zhou and Chang, 2024), and users' evaluations of influencer traits and parasocial relationships (Liu and Zheng, 2024).

2.1.1 Central Route: Information Authenticity

Information authenticity refers to whether information is original and independently expressed, rather than copied or imitated from others (Grayson and Martinec, 2004). This attribute provides users with a basis for assessing credibility and supports content filtering during the information reception process. However, content on social media platforms is often shaped by users' subjective editing and reinterpretation rather than derived from firsthand facts, reducing both its originality and perceived credibility (Lv and Wokutch, 2024). In such environments, users increasingly rely on their own perceptions of authenticity when evaluating content. The question of whether information is authentic thus becomes a key criterion for triggering central route processing. Information authenticity not only offers a verifiable cognitive cue but also serves as a critical reference for maintaining cognitive control and avoiding misinformation in complex digital contexts.

2.1.2 Central Route: Information Literacy

Information literacy refers to an individual's ability to identify, evaluate, and use information effectively, particularly in digital environments where assessing authenticity and credibility is essential (Gilster and Glister, 1997). As a subset of media literacy (Koltay, 2011), it plays a crucial role in enabling users to critically process online content and resist misinformation. Research shows that individuals with higher information literacy demonstrate stronger critical thinking and are more discerning in evaluating ambiguous content (Jones-Jang *et al.,* 2021; Apuke *et al.,* 2023). Within ELM, information literacy facilitates central route processing by equipping users to base decisions on content quality rather than superficial cues.

2.1.3 Peripheral Route: Uses and Gratifications Theory (UGT)

The Uses and Gratifications Theory (UGT) provides a foundational perspective on media use, emphasizing users' active role in selecting content to meet psychological and social needs (Katz *et al.,* 1973; Xu *et al.,* 2024). On short video platforms, common gratifications include information seeking, status enhancement, entertainment, and socialization (Palmgreen, 1984; Chen *et al.,* 2025), while passing time has also emerged as a salient motivator (Sun and Xie, 2024). Recent studies have extended UGT to mobile environments, revealing how gratification mechanisms support relational, informational, and experiential engagement (Kamboj, 2020; Wang and Oh, 2023).

In the context of ELM, the peripheral route reflects low-effort processing guided by emotional responses or heuristic cues (Petty *et al.,* 1986), consistent with UGT's focus on hedonic and social motivations. Accordingly, this study incorporates four constructs—status seeking, socialization, entertainment, and passing time—to examine how users form behavioral intentions via the peripheral route.

Socialization

Socialization refers to individuals' use of media to fulfill their need for communication and interaction with others—a need rooted in the fundamental human drive for belonging and social connection (Whiting and Williams, 2013). As social media technologies have evolved, users' modes of interaction have also changed significantly. By eliminating temporal and spatial constraints, social media platforms offer more immediate and efficient communication channels, expanding the boundaries of traditional social engagement (Sun and Xie, 2024). Through such interactions, individuals gain emotional support, reinforce self-identity, and strengthen their sense of social integration.

Status Seeking

Status seeking describes users' psychological motivation to enhance their sense of superiority and social recognition through media use (Katz *et al.,* 1973). Social media provides a platform for self-presentation, validation, and feedback, enabling users to fulfill their internal drive for elevated status. By sharing content, expressing opinions, or contributing to discussions, users can gain attention and admiration from peers, thereby enhancing their perceived standing within specific social groups (Lee and Ma, 2012). Prior research shows that the desire for social status is a key driver of active participation, often associated with higher engagement levels and greater willingness to create content (Yan *et al.,* 2021).

Passing Time

Passing time refers to the motivation to use media in the absence of specific tasks, often to relieve boredom or fill idle moments—especially by casually browsing or sharing content on social platforms (Thompson *et al.,* 2020). Within the framework of UGT, passing time is recognized as a basic and prevalent driver of everyday media use, particularly in mobile and short-form content contexts (Baek *et al.,* 2011).

Entertainment

Entertainment refers to the psychological gratification users derive from engaging in enjoyable media activities, such as relaxing, escaping stress, or seeking amusement (Apuke and Omar, 2021). On social media platforms, users pursue entertainment through content consumption, video sharing, or participation in interactive features. Studies have shown that entertainment is a major motivational factor in continued engagement and content sharing on digital platforms (Qiao *et al.,* 2024). From a hedonistic perspective, researchers have further explored how users interact with virtual entertainment environments, confirming the widespread appeal of entertainment in digital media use (Abbasi *et al.,* 2024).

2.2 Trust in Information

Trust in information is users' belief in the authenticity, reliability, and integrity of content, serving as a key psychological mechanism for processing and responding to information (O'Neill, 2018). In virtual environments, trust bridges distance and enables ongoing social interaction, but social media's fragmented and often low-credibility content complicates trust formation (Jarvenpaa & Leidner, 1998; Shahbazi & Bunker, 2024).

A primary antecedent of trust is perceived authenticity; natural and hard-to-fake content fosters greater trust and engagement (Lee & Eastin, 2021). Studies confirm that authenticity enhances perceived credibility for both content creators (Chen et al., 2022) and online reviews (Brinson & Lemon, 2023), and that authenticity and credibility are closely linked in digital contexts (Wang & Weng, 2024).

Information literacy—users' ability to identify credible sources and assess quality—also strengthens trust, as individuals with higher literacy base judgments on logic and evidence, making them more resilient to misinformation (Eveleth et al., 2024).

Accordingly, the following hypotheses are proposed:

H1a. Information authenticity positively influences users' trust in information.

H1b. Information literacy positively influences users' trust in information.

2.3 Intention to Share Information

Intention to share information refers to users' voluntary dissemination of content without direct rewards, playing a key role in social media behaviors (Hu and Noor, 2024). Trust in information is crucial, as perceived authenticity and credibility increase users' willingness to share by lowering perceived risks (Sun and Xie, 2024; Laato *et al.,* 2020).

In addition, UGT identifies multiple psychological drivers of sharing behaviors, including status seeking for recognition and social validation (Thompson *et al.,* 2020), socialization for relationship maintenance and interpersonal connection (Choi, 2016), entertainment for emotional expression and enjoyment (Chao *et al.,* 2025), and passing time to alleviate boredom during idle periods (Sampat and Raj, 2022).

Based on the above, the following hypotheses are formulated:

H2a. Socialization positively influences users' intention to share information.

H2b. Status seeking positively influences users' intention to share information.

H2c. Passing time positively influences users' intention to share information.

H2d. Entertainment positively influences users' intention to share information.

H3. Trust in information positively influences users' intention to share information.

H7a. Trust in information mediates the relationship between information authenticity and intention to share information.

H7b. Trust in information mediates the relationship between information literacy and intention to share information.

2.4 Continuance Intention

Continuance intention describes users' motivation to sustain engagement with a platform, shaped by trust in information and sharing intention (He et al., 2024). Key drivers include entertainment, information seeking, social interaction, and self-presentation (Hsu et al., 2015). Both utilitarian and hedonic values influence this intention, reflecting users' pursuit of practical and emotional benefits (Ji et al., 2024). Some studies highlight a "benefit–intention" pathway, where perceived rewards drive continued usage, and note that motivational factors may impact continuance intention indirectly via increased sharing willingness (Fan et al., 2023).

The following hypotheses are proposed:

H4. Trust in information positively influences users' continuance intention.

H5. Intention to share information positively influences users' continuance intention.

H8a. Trust in information mediates the relationship between information authenticity and continuance intention.

H8b. Trust in information mediates the relationship between information literacy and continuance intention.

H9a. Intention to share information mediates the relationship between socialization and continuance intention.

H9b. Intention to share information mediates the relationship between status seeking and continuance intention.

H9c. Intention to share information mediates the relationship between passing time and continuance intention.

H9d. Intention to share information mediates the relationship between entertainment and continuance intention.

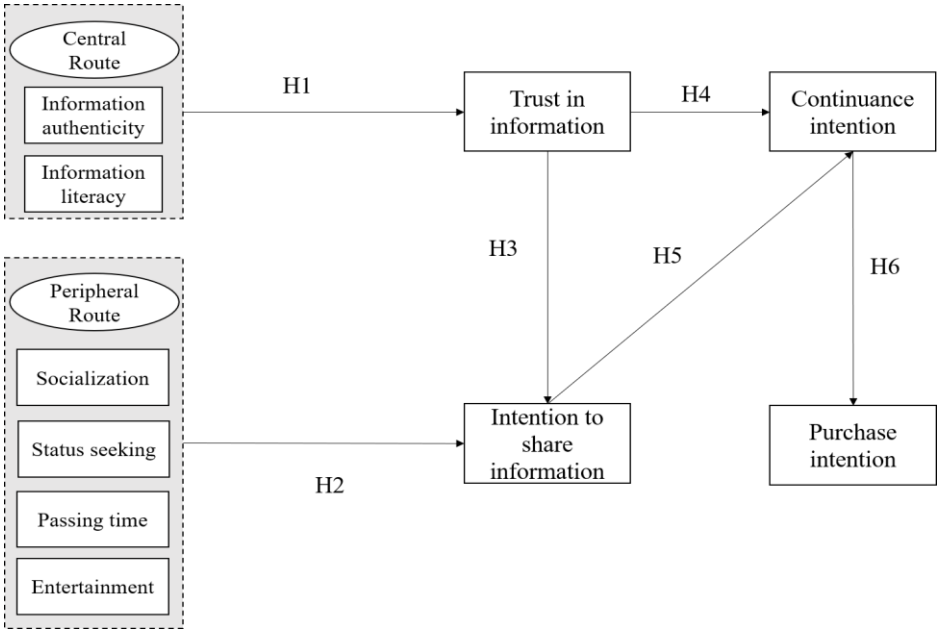

Figure1. Research Model

3 Research method

3.1 Measurement

All measurement scales were adapted from previously validated instruments (see Appendix 1) and modified to fit the Chinese context and the short-form video platform environment. A back-translation procedure was employed to ensure semantic consistency: items were first translated from English to Chinese and then back to English for reporting purposes.

The measurement of information authenticity was adapted from Metzger et al. (2010), while information literacy was measured based on the framework developed by Bawden (2008). Items for uses and gratifications constructs were modified from Thompson et al. (2020). The scale for trust in information was adapted from Zhang et al., (2024). Intention to share information was based on Kim et al. (2018), and continuance intention was derived from Li and Shang (2020). Purchase intention items were adapted from Kim et al. (2025). All constructs were measured using a 7-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree), following Triandis (1996).

3.2 Data Collection

The questionnaire was designed and distributed via the Chinese online platform https://www.wjx.cn and disseminated through WeChat, ensuring broad reach and demographic coverage. The survey was anonymous to protect privacy, and a small monetary incentive (1–3 RMB) was offered to encourage participation.

A total of 652 valid responses were collected between March and April 2025. The cross-sectional design, implemented across multiple TikTok-focused WeChat groups, allowed efficient measurement of variable relationships with minimal external interference, in line with behavioral research practices (Wang and Cheng, 2020).

Descriptive statistics (Table 1) were used to assess sample representativeness based on gender, age, education, and income. Gender distribution was nearly balanced (51.8% male, 48.2% female), providing a basis for multigroup analysis. The majority of respondents were aged 25–35 (51.4%), followed by those over 36 (29.9%), reflecting the core demographic of short-form video platform users.

Educational attainment was high, with 68.7% holding a bachelor’s degree and 20.6% a graduate degree, indicating

sufficient cognitive ability for information evaluation. Monthly income levels showed moderate to strong purchasing power: 46.9% earned RMB 5,001–10,000, 26.1% RMB 3,001–5,000, and 18.9% over RMB 10,000.

In sum, the sample demonstrated demographic diversity and representativeness, supporting the robustness of subsequent SEM and multigroup analyses.

Table 1. Demographic information.

Particulars	Description	Values	%
Gender	Male	338	51.8%
	Female	314	48.2%
Age(years)	≤18	61	9.4%
	18-25	61	9.4%
	25-35	335	51.4%
	≥36	195	29.9%
Education level	≤ high school degree	70	10.7%
	university degree	448	68.7%
	postgraduate degree	134	20.6%
Revenue (RMB/Month)	≤3000	53	8.1%
	3001- 5000	170	26.1%
	5001-10000	306	46.9%
	10001-15000	84	12.9%
	≥15001	39	6.0%

4 Data analysis and results

4.1 Reliability and Validity

Preliminary analysis confirmed the dataset's suitability for factor analysis, with a KMO value of 0.886 and Bartlett's test of sphericity (χ^2 = 10,634.793, df = 703, $p < 0.001$). Exploratory factor analysis extracted ten factors with eigenvalues above 1, accounting for 68.812% of the total variance.

PLS-SEM analysis (300 iterations) showed all factor loadings exceeded 0.70. Cronbach's α and composite reliability (CR) values for all constructs were above 0.70, and average variance extracted (AVE) values exceeded 0.50, confirming internal consistency and convergent validity.

Table 2. Results of reliability and validity

Construct	Loadings	VIF	Cronbach's alpha	CA	CR	AVE
Information authenticity (IA)			0.878	0.881	0.911	0.672
IA1	0.828	1.971				
IA2	0.806	1.951				
IA3	0.812	1.981				
IA4	0.835	2.228				
IA5	0.818	2.004				
Information literacy (IL)			0.838	0.850	0.891	0.672
IL1	0.796	1.757				
IL2	0.817	1.765				
IL3	0.822	1.953				
IL4	0.844	1.831				
Socialization (SOC)			0.844	0.844	0.895	0.681
SOC1	0.815	1.806				
SOC2	0.809	1.750				
SOC3	0.834	1.937				
SOC4	0.841	1.974				
Status seeking (SS)			0.830	0.835	0.887	0.662

SS1	0.818	1.724				
SS2	0.793	1.724				
SS3	0.818	1.873				
SS4	0.824	1.746				
Passing time（PT）			0.845	0.846	0.895	0.682
PT1	0.811	1.800				
PT2	0.829	1.932				
PT3	0.828	1.850				
PT4	0.834	1.871				
Entertainment (ENT)			0.845	0.852	0.895	0.681
ENT1	0.817	1.864				
ENT2	0.838	1.814				
ENT3	0.815	1.890				
ENT4	0.831	1.892				
Trust in information (TI)			0.839	0.848	0.892	0.674
TI1	0.809	1.844				
TI2	0.837	1.847				
TI3	0.800	1.798				
TI4	0.836	1.813				
Intention to share information (ISI)			0.778	0.781	0.871	0.692
ISI1	0.848	1.629				
ISI2	0.833	1.662				
ISI3	0.815	1.546				
Continuance intention (CI)			0.799	0.807	0.882	0.713
CI1	0.856	1.672				
CI2	0.823	1.709				
CI3	0.854	1.750				
Purchase intention (PI)			0.795	0.800	0.879	0.709
PI1	0.820	1.643				
PI2	0.838	1.655				
PI3	0.866	1.778				

Discriminant validity was confirmed using the Fornell–Larcker criterion, as the square root of AVE for each construct was greater than the highest inter-construct correlation (Table 3). Additional confirmation came from HTMT ratios, all well below the 0.85 threshold (Table 4).

Table 3. Discriminant validity (Fornell-Larcker criterion)

Construct	CI	ENT	IA	IL	ISI	PI	PT	SOC	SS	TI
CI	0.844									
ENT	0.284	0.825								
IA	0.246	0.293	0.820							
IL	0.249	0.284	0.171	0.820						
ISI	0.232	0.317	0.282	0.169	0.832					
PI	0.210	0.244	0.199	0.209	0.195	0.842				
PT	0.240	0.248	0.259	0.221	0.307	0.220	0.826			
SOC	0.205	0.310	0.295	0.240	0.301	0.298	0.210	0.825		
SS	0.241	0.276	0.232	0.237	0.305	0.169	0.260	0.262	0.813	
TI	0.229	0.304	0.251	0.288	0.299	0.261	0.252	0.246	0.264	0.821

Table 4. Discriminant validity (HTMT)

Construct	CI	ENT	IA	IL	ISI	PI	PT	SOC	SS	TI
CI										
ENT	0.342									
IA	0.293	0.336								
IL	0.304	0.333	0.198							
ISI	0.293	0.387	0.341	0.211						
PI	0.261	0.298	0.239	0.251	0.247					
PT	0.295	0.290	0.300	0.265	0.377	0.267				
SOC	0.247	0.367	0.342	0.283	0.369	0.364	0.248			
SS	0.296	0.326	0.270	0.282	0.376	0.208	0.306	0.312		
TI	0.273	0.356	0.289	0.336	0.364	0.321	0.295	0.290	0.315	

4.2 Multicollinearity and Explanatory Power

All VIF values were below the 3.3 threshold (Table 2), indicating no multicollinearity issues. Adjusted R^2 values demonstrated satisfactory explanatory power for Trust in Information (0.123), Intention to Share Information (0.222), Continuance Intention (0.079), and Purchase Intention (0.043), exceeding benchmark levels.

Effect sizes (F^2) also met recommended criteria (Table 5). Stone–Geisser's Q^2 values were above zero for all dependent variables—0.082 (Trust), 0.151 (Sharing Intention), 0.056 (Continuance Intention), and 0.030 (Purchase Intention)—indicating good predictive relevance. Model fit was acceptable with SRMR = 0.040 and NFI = 0.843.

Table 5. f-square

Construct	f-square	Construct	f-square
IA → TI	0.048	ENT → ISI	0.023
IL → TI	0.071	TI → ISI	0.020
SOC → ISI	0.024	TI → CI	0.030
SS → ISI	0.023	ISI → CI	0.032
PT → ISI	0.031	CI → PI	0.046

4.3 Hypothesis Testing

PLS path analysis with 5,000 bootstrap resamples supported all hypotheses (Table 6; Figure 2). On the central route, both information authenticity ($\beta = 0.208$, $p < 0.001$) and information literacy ($\beta = 0.253$, $p < 0.001$) significantly increased trust in information, with literacy having a slightly stronger effect.

On the peripheral route, each motivational factor had a significant impact on sharing intention: socialization ($\beta = 0.146$, $p < 0.001$), status seeking ($\beta = 0.150$, $p < 0.001$), entertainment ($\beta = 0.153$, $p < 0.001$), and passing time ($\beta = 0.166$, $p < 0.001$), with passing time being the strongest predictor.

Mediation analysis (Table 7) revealed that both information authenticity and literacy indirectly influenced sharing and continuance intentions via trust: IA → Trust → Share ($\beta = 0.029$, T = 3.056), IL → Trust → Share ($\beta = 0.035$, T = 3.292), IA → Trust → Continuance ($\beta = 0.036$, T = 3.566), and IL → Trust → Continuance ($\beta = 0.044$, T = 3.893).

Similarly, all gratification factors indirectly influenced continuance intention via sharing intention: socialization ($\beta = 0.027$, T = 3.024), status seeking ($\beta = 0.026$, T = 2.860), passing time ($\beta = 0.030$, T = 3.217), and entertainment ($\beta = 0.027$, T = 2.805). VAF values confirmed full mediation for H7–H9 (Hayes & Rockwood, 2017).

Table 6. Path coefficients and hypothesis testing

Hypothesis	Paths	Path factor	Sample mean	STDEV	T/P statistics	Conclusion
H1a	IA → TI	0.208	0.211	0.034	6.160***	Support
H1b	IL →TI	0.253	0.255	0.034	7.475***	Support
H2a	SOC → ISI	0.148	0.150	0.036	4.079***	Support

H2b	SS → ISI	0.146	0.147	0.037	3.921***	Support
H2c	PT → ISI	0.166	0.168	0.036	4.682***	Support
H2d	ENT → ISI	0.149	0.149	0.037	4.039***	Support
H3	TI → ISI	0.137	0.137	0.037	3.708***	Support
H4	TI → CI	0.175	0.177	0.036	4.870***	Support
H5	ISI → CI	0.180	0.181	0.038	4.762***	Support
H6	CI → PI	0.210	0.214	0.036	5.898***	Support

Note: *p<0.05, **p<0.01, ***p<0.001.

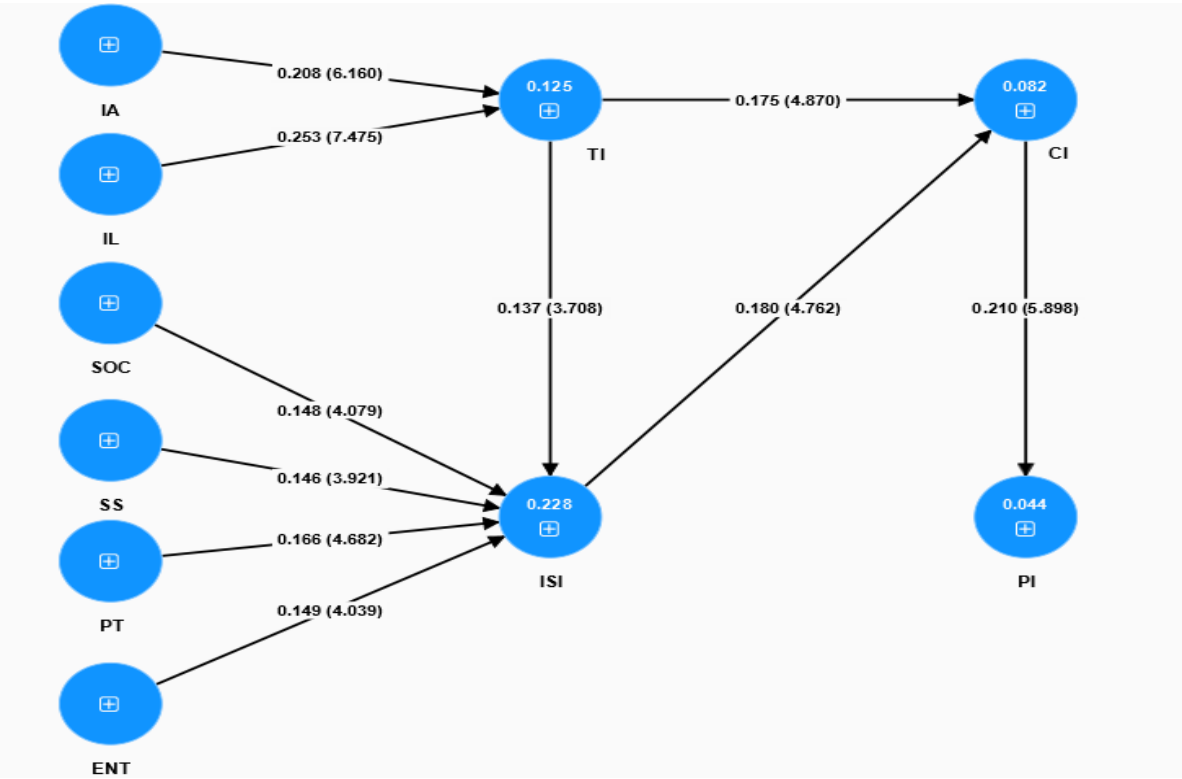

Figure 2. Hypotheses Result

Table7. Mediation effect test

Hypothesis	Paths	Path factor	Sample mean	STDEV	T values	Conclusion
H7a	IA → TI → ISI	0.029	0.029	0.009	3.056**	Support
H7b	IL → TI → ISI	0.035	0.035	0.011	3.292**	Support
H8a	IA → TI → CI	0.036	0.037	0.010	3.566***	Support
H8b	IL → TI → CI	0.044	0.045	0.011	3.893***	Support
H9a	SOC → ISI → CI	0.027	0.027	0.009	3.024**	Support
H9b	SS → ISI → CI	0.026	0.027	0.009	2.860**	Support
H9c	PT → ISI → CI	0.030	0.030	0.009	3.217**	Support
H9d	ENT → ISI → CI	0.027	0.027	0.010	2.805*	Support

Note: *p<0.05, **p<0.01, ***p<0.001.

5 Conclusion

This study investigates how information authenticity, information literacy, and UGT–based motivations shape users' trust in information, intention to share, continuance intention, and ultimately purchase intention on short video platforms. Drawing on a Chinese user sample and employing SEM, the analysis confirms all proposed hypotheses. In particular, the results validate

the mediating roles of information trust and sharing intention in both the central processing route (information authenticity, information literacy) and the peripheral route (entertainment, socialization, status seeking, and passing time) in influencing users' continued engagement and purchase behavior. These findings contribute to the growing body of research on short video platform user behavior and provide insights for theory and practice (Fan et al., 2021; Shi et al., 2023; Thompson et al., 2020).

First, the results show that both information authenticity and information literacy significantly enhance users' trust in information. This finding supports Zhang and Patrick's (2021) argument that authentic content fosters user acceptance and trust, and aligns with Hobbs (2013), who emphasizes the role of media literacy in enhancing individuals' critical evaluation skills. In the context of short-form video, trust is grounded in both the perceived authenticity of content and users' cognitive capacity to assess information quality. As generative AI (AIGC) becomes increasingly prevalent, the interplay between authenticity perception and literacy competence grows more critical. Survey results further support this mechanism, as respondents agreed with items such as "I verify the credibility of information through multiple sources" and "I can quickly assess the authenticity of short video content."

Second, entertainment, socialization, status seeking, and passing time motivations each positively influence users' intention to share. Among these, passing time emerged as the strongest predictor, corroborating Thompson et al. (2020)'s claim that low-effort gratifications play a major role in fast-paced, emotionally driven interactions. Other motives—such as enjoyment, relationship maintenance, and identity signaling—also significantly influenced sharing behavior, confirming the applicability of UGT to the short video environment (Xu et al., 2024). Survey data reinforce these findings, with users expressing agreement with statements like "Sharing short videos helps me relax" and "I share content to express my views," highlighting the psychological immediacy and social validation embedded in sharing practices.

Third, both trust in information and intention to share have direct positive effects on users' continuance intention. This finding echoes Sun et al. (2020), who suggest that platform engagement is a key antecedent to purchase behavior, and extends this view by identifying sharing intention as a critical precursor to sustained usage. Survey responses support these relationships, with users indicating strong alignment with "I enjoy sharing short video content" and "I trust the content on short video platforms," underscoring the dual roles of cognitive and behavioral engagement in fostering loyalty.

Fourth, the study confirms a significant positive relationship between continuance intention and purchase intention. This finding aligns with prior research (Wang and Cheng, 2020; Sun et al., 2020), which highlights the link between continued usage and transactional behavior. User responses further reflect this pattern, showing a preference for short video platforms as primary channels for product discovery and purchase, suggesting that ongoing engagement is not only a function of entertainment or habit but also a driver of commercial action.

Finally, the study reveals that both central and peripheral path variables exert indirect effects on user behavior through the mediators of trust and sharing. Information authenticity and literacy enhance users' sharing and continuance intentions via increased trust, emphasizing the cognitive foundations of engagement. Simultaneously, the four gratification-based motivations affect continuance intention indirectly via sharing, highlighting the role of emotional and social drivers in user trajectories.

Gender-based multigroup analysis uncovers notable differences in motivational pathways. Female users are more influenced by emotional and social motives, particularly entertainment and socialization, and are more likely to convert continuance into purchase intention. In contrast, male users are more strongly motivated by passing time and status, focusing on efficiency and symbolic expression. These findings suggest that gender-tailored strategies may enhance platform engagement by aligning content and marketing initiatives with the distinct psychological profiles and behavioral tendencies of different user groups (Won et al., 2023).

6 Conclusion and implications

6.1 Theoretical implications

First, this study integrates ELM and UGT to construct a dual-pathway framework following the logic of "cognition–trust–motivation–behavior." By incorporating information authenticity and information literacy as central-route variables, along with

multiple user motivations—such as entertainment, socialization, status seeking, and passing time—as peripheral-route factors, the model provides a more comprehensive explanation of user behavior on short video platforms. This approach advances existing theory by highlighting the joint influence of cognitive elaboration and psychological motivations on digital engagement.

Second, the study enriches the understanding of user behavior progression by integrating both continuance intention and purchase intention into a unified structural model. It systematically traces the behavioral path from information evaluation and trust, through sharing and continued use, to eventual purchase intention. This sequential framework offers new insights into how digital engagement translates into consumption behavior, deepening our understanding of conversion mechanisms in short video ecosystems.

Finally, the research incorporates a gender-based multigroup analysis to examine variations in the structural model. The results reveal significant gender differences in information processing and motivational pathways: female users are more influenced by emotional and social gratifications, while male users are more driven by status-seeking and time-passing motives. Moreover, continuance intention has a stronger predictive effect on purchase intention among female users. These findings provide empirical support for the model's subgroup applicability and offer a theoretical foundation for future studies on gender-specific digital behavior.

6.2 Practical implications

This study offers several practical insights for the operation and management of short video platforms. First, the findings highlight the critical role of information authenticity and information literacy in shaping user trust, which in turn influences content sharing and continued platform usage. In increasingly complex content environments driven by AIGC, platform managers should prioritize enhancing users' perceptions of information credibility and quality. Practical measures may include implementing content provenance tracking, credibility labeling, and rumor-correction mechanisms to foster trust in the platform's information ecosystem. For instance, some platforms have begun incorporating indicators such as "original source disclosure" or "AI-generated content tags" within video descriptions, enhancing transparency and meeting users' cognitive trust-building needs. This study provides empirical support for the effectiveness of such trust-enhancing mechanisms in influencing user behavior.

Second, the study confirms that various motivational factors—including entertainment, social interaction, status seeking, and passing time—significantly influence users' intention to share content. This suggests that user sharing is not solely driven by content evaluation but also by the need for immediate gratification and social connection. Accordingly, platform designers should tailor incentive schemes and content recommendation algorithms to align with users' motivational profiles. For example, incorporating indicators such as "social activity levels" or "frequency of interactive feedback" into recommendation models may enhance content sharing and user engagement. Moreover, the observed gender-based differences in motivational responsiveness and behavioral pathways suggest that incorporating gender as a segmentation variable could improve the precision of personalized recommendations and user retention strategies, ultimately boosting platform stickiness and commercial conversion.

Third, the study demonstrates that continuance intention significantly predicts purchase intention, indicating that frequent engagement with short video platforms not only reflects content-related loyalty but also facilitates in-app consumer behavior. This finding provides behavioral validation for the growing trend of integrating content consumption with e-commerce features. Platforms such as TikTok and Kuaishou have increasingly adopted "content-as-commerce" models, linking information feeds directly to product offerings to reduce user friction in the conversion from viewing to purchasing. The empirical evidence in this study suggests that optimizing the user experience during content interaction can enhance both sustained engagement and transactional potential.

In summary, this study offers actionable insights into users' cognitive processing and behavioral conversion mechanisms. By addressing cognitive, motivational, and demographic dimensions, the findings provide a practical foundation for optimizing content governance, user engagement strategies, and commercialization pathways in short video platforms.

6.3 Limitations and Future Research

This study proposes a dual-pathway model of short video user behavior, yet several limitations warrant further exploration.

First, the model emphasizes individual cognition and motivation but overlooks platform-level factors such as algorithm design and content structure, which significantly shape user behavior. Future research should integrate environmental variables to improve contextual relevance. Second, while cognitive constructs like information authenticity and literacy are included, deeper psychological mechanisms—such as emotional responses, cognitive load, or attention—are not addressed. Incorporating such mediators may offer a more nuanced view of user processing in fast-paced content settings. Third, the gender-based analysis reveals meaningful subgroup differences, but other moderating factors—e.g., age, media literacy, and cultural background—remain unexplored. Future studies should consider a broader range of heterogeneity to enhance generalizability. Finally, reliance on self-reported data limits objectivity. Future work could adopt mixed methods such as behavioral logs, eye-tracking, or content analysis to improve external validity. Overall, future research should refine theoretical depth, expand psychological mechanisms, and diversify data sources to advance a more comprehensive understanding of user engagement on short video platforms.

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